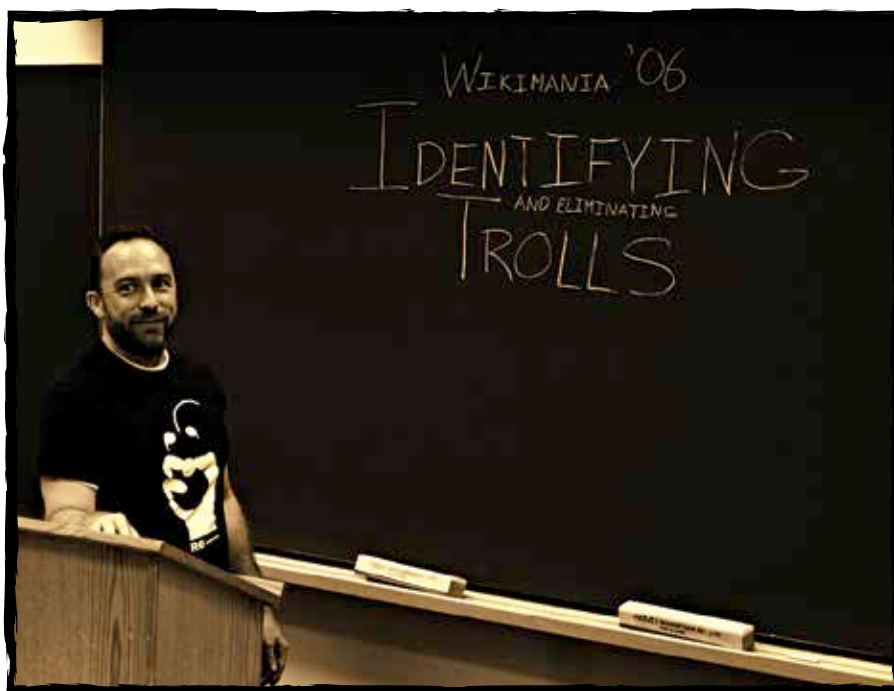




Wikipedia is especially prone to troll attacks because of the way the site works

then those very sites were provided as the citations for the information. Basically there was a scientist called Edward Teller, who is sometimes called “father of the hydrogen bomb” because of the designs he helped create for nuclear weapons. It just so happened that he was the right age to possibly be related to a magician called Teller (from Penn and Teller), and the Wikipedia page claimed Edward Teller was the father of the magician Teller. This was an edit made by a known vandal, and was later on changed, but it was information that was stuck in this writer’s brain for a long time. Sadly, by the time the error was discovered, we’d already printed the book, and had to print a correction the next month. However, it was a prime example why Wikipedia cannot be trusted, and certainly, a lot of fact checking is needed for information posted online.

There are many more examples, but this is the one topic where you might have read a lot of articles before, and you can always Google to know more. What’s not as common is perhaps looking at older examples of troll-like behaviour, which may or may not have been planned.

FAMOUS ANCIENT ACTS OF TROLLING

We are going to stretch the definition of troll-like behaviour for this, because, well, this is perhaps from where the inspiration for a lot of modern day trolls stems from. Let’s look at that in the form of an example. Take the bronze age story of Troy, and even though it (supposedly) happened over 3,000 years ago, so many of us know all about the Trojan war. Heck, we even name certain types of malware “trojans” because they pretend to be something they’re not (or contain malicious code in an otherwise harmless looking package). For over 3,000 years the story of the Trojan Horse has been told, about how a deception was able to win a war for the Greeks – and by inference is something to be celebrated. Although we can’t say the Greeks trolled the Trojans, you do understand the point we’re making here about how if you broaden the definition of trolling, you can see the same mental processes of deception being used, even in much more practical times.

A much more recent example of a deception was the telling of a story adapted from H.G. Wells’ novel, *War of the Worlds* on the radio by Orson Welles

in 1938. The story of Martians attacking Earth, and the detail in which it was narrated, was said to have caused a mass panic. However, it wasn’t the radio station, or even Orson Welles who was trolling, because it’s now believed that actually there was no panic, and in fact the station which broadcast the episode had very few listeners to begin with. In an attempt to “troll”, it was newspapers who hyped the event and made it seem like a million people were terrified and trembling at this radio prank. This is because radio was still new, and was stealing big bucks in advertising money away from the newspapers, and thus some newspapers thought it would be a good idea to hype the whole thing in order to discredit radio as a source for serious information. We leave judgments about whether the newspapers failed or succeeded to others, however, it was, as far as we can tell, a deliberate pre-internet era example of trolling.

Not all examples of such deviant behaviour are for fun. Some are devious and clearly for profit, though many would argue that profit alone cannot explain the deep desire of a person to try and fool people. It’s also extremely pleasurable to be able to “pull one over” otherwise intelligent people, and to be able to fool experts is just got to be an incredible feeling for a troll.

A famous British art forger, Shaun Greenhalgh, who was most active from 1990 to 2005, is a prime example of someone being able to fool experts, in their own field of study. The most famous forgery was called the *Armana Princess*, which is a headless sculpture that Shaun whipped up in his shed in under three weeks, but his father was able to sell it by fooling multiple experts from the Bolton Museum, the British Museum and also famous auction house Christie’s. The sculpture was bought by the Bolton Museum for a whopping 440,000 pounds (in 2003). When the family was caught, finally, these experts were left with egg on their faces.

Pierre de Fermat, the French lawyer and mathematician, once wrote a theorem